

FOOD

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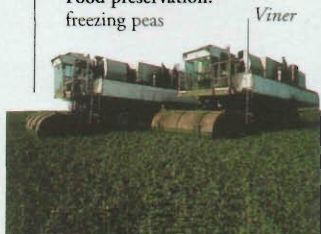
WE ARE WHAT WE EAT: our bodies get the energy and nourishment they need from our daily diet. Not having enough of the right food, or eating too much of the wrong food, causes ill-health. Food and eating are important in other ways too. Many countries have a distinctive cuisine (cooking style), which reflects the eating habits of its people and the ingredients available locally. In many industrialized nations, cooking is a hobby as well as a necessary task. Today there is concern about levels of chemicals in food, and many people choose an organic diet.

Processing and preserving

Even before they are cooked, most foods must be processed to make them ready for cooking: for example, wheat must be ground into flour before it can be baked as bread. Preserving food allows it to be stored for use later; this reduces the risk of shortages, and prolongs availability. A food industry has grown up to provide the food we eat, and process, preserve, and package it.

Food preservation:
freezing peas

Viner



Frozen peas



1 Until frozen peas were invented, the only peas most people could eat were dried or tinned. A machine called a viner harvests the peas when they are sweet enough to be frozen. It tumbles them in a drum to remove the pods. These are ploughed back into the field as fertilizer.

2 Once at the factory, the peas are washed and blanched. They are then carried on a conveyor to the freezing chamber. On the way, jets of cold air prevent them sticking together. In the chamber, the peas are blast-frozen at a temperature of -18°C (-2°F).

3 Before packaging, the peas are assessed for quality and taste. Fresh vegetables begin to lose their nutrients as soon as they are picked. Because these peas have been frozen within two and a half hours, they are fresher than fresh peas in a shop.



Chocolate

Chocolate is a food product derived from the cocoa bean. The Aztecs of Mexico enjoyed a chocolate drink, flavoured with chilli. When the Spanish conquered Mexico in the 16th century, they introduced the drink to Europe. People began to eat solid chocolate from about 1630, but chocolate bars were a luxury until the 20th century.

Frozen food

Freezing food to preserve it dates from prehistoric times in cold regions. Following the appearance of home electric refrigerators in 1913, frozen vegetables first went on sale in the USA in 1930.



Peas in the pod

Frozen vegetables



Fast food is food that is mass-prepared and served quickly in takeaway outlets. The hamburger is a popular fast food in many western countries.

A delicacy in France



Frog's legs

Popular in Japan



Seaweed

Made with pig's blood



Black pudding



Snails

Jews and Muslims do not eat pork.



Pork sausages

What is food?

Anything humans can digest counts as food. Worldwide, diets vary widely: food habits are influenced by availability, climate, and religious, moral, or social factors. Ideally, a daily diet should include staple, energy-giving carbohydrates, such as rice or pasta, plus proteins, fats, vitamins, and minerals. In reality, poverty or warfare make this impossible in many places.

Preparing food

Although some foods, such as salad vegetables and fruit, are delicious when raw, many foods need to be cooked first. Cooking makes food tastier and easier to digest. Cooking root vegetables, for instance, makes their starch grains absorb water, swell, and burst, releasing essential nutrients.

Salad



Orange



Steaming fish is a healthy way to cook it.

Cooking methods

There are many cooking methods, such as simmering food in water, which heats it to just under 100°C (212°F). Only a few foods, such as eggs, cook at temperatures lower than this. Grilling or frying in oil heats food to a much higher temperature, cooking it faster.

Hunger and famine

Each year, 800 million people cannot get enough food to lead healthy lives, despite food surpluses in other parts of the world. Children suffer most. Malnutrition in children severely damages their physical and mental development. Every year in the developing world, famine (widespread starvation) occurs when insects, plant diseases, drought, or warfare destroy crops, and a harvest fails.



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